

PRESENTATION BY THE WORKSHOP FACILITATOR

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A Workshop to Develop Curriculum-Based Accreditation Criteria for Pharmacy

Technicians' Training Programmes in the ECOWAS Region

ORGANISED BY

West African Health Organization (WAHO) Headquarters

Bobo-Dioulasso, Burkina Faso

July 2-3, 2013

Preamble

The Pharmacy Technician Programme is designed to provide auxiliary training to students, primarily in Schools of Health Technology (SHTs), to qualify them as Pharmacy Technicians (PTs). These professionals fill the much-needed middle-level Human Resources for Health (HRH) gap and serve as support personnel to pharmacists.

Over time, Pharmacy Technicians have become recognized as a vital technical auxiliary cadre, providing services especially at Primary Health Centres and General or Cottage Hospitals for secondary healthcare delivery. It is also not uncommon to find PTs in Teaching Hospitals, Federal Medical Centres (FMCs), and other tertiary healthcare institutions, where they provide support services to pharmacists.

In Nigeria, the training of Pharmacy Technicians in SHTs is supervised by the Pharmacy Department of each school, under a pharmacist designated as Head of Department (HoD). Accreditation of the PT programme is conducted by the Pharmacists Council of Nigeria (PCN) through duly constituted accreditation teams of the Governing Council.

The curriculum of the PT programme is prepared by the PCN and handed down to SHTs. Accreditation follows a structured process using a specially designed form (FORM PTI) and the approved curriculum, which must be fully in place during both initial and re-accreditation exercises.

This workshop has therefore been convened to develop curriculum-based accreditation criteria for Pharmacy Technician Training Programmes in the ECOWAS region, drawing lessons from Nigeria and other countries. The ultimate goal is to harmonize accreditation standards across the region.

This paper is presented as a foundation for discussions at this two-day workshop.

1. The Roles of Pharmacy Regulatory Agencies

Pharmacy Regulatory Agencies—whether Pharmacists Councils, Pharmacy Councils, or Pharmacy Boards—are established to regulate and control pharmacy education and practice in all its dimensions within member countries of the region.

These agencies must take full responsibility for accreditation, training, examinations, licensing (or issuance of permits) for Pharmacy Technicians. This ensures that graduates can properly deliver essential pharmaceutical services at the middle level, under the supervision of trained and licensed pharmacists.

The functions of Regulatory Agencies in PT training can be summarized as follows:

- Curriculum Development
- Accreditation Requirements and Evaluation Format
- Designation of Institutions for PT Training, including student entry requirements, quotas, and physical infrastructure standards
- Indexing and Examinations
- Registration, Issuance of Licenses/Permits, and Fees
- Continuing Education, Workshops, and “Train-the-Trainers” programmes

1.1 Curriculum Development

A Pharmacy Regulatory Agency should be structured in a way that places curriculum development and training manual design under the appropriate department.

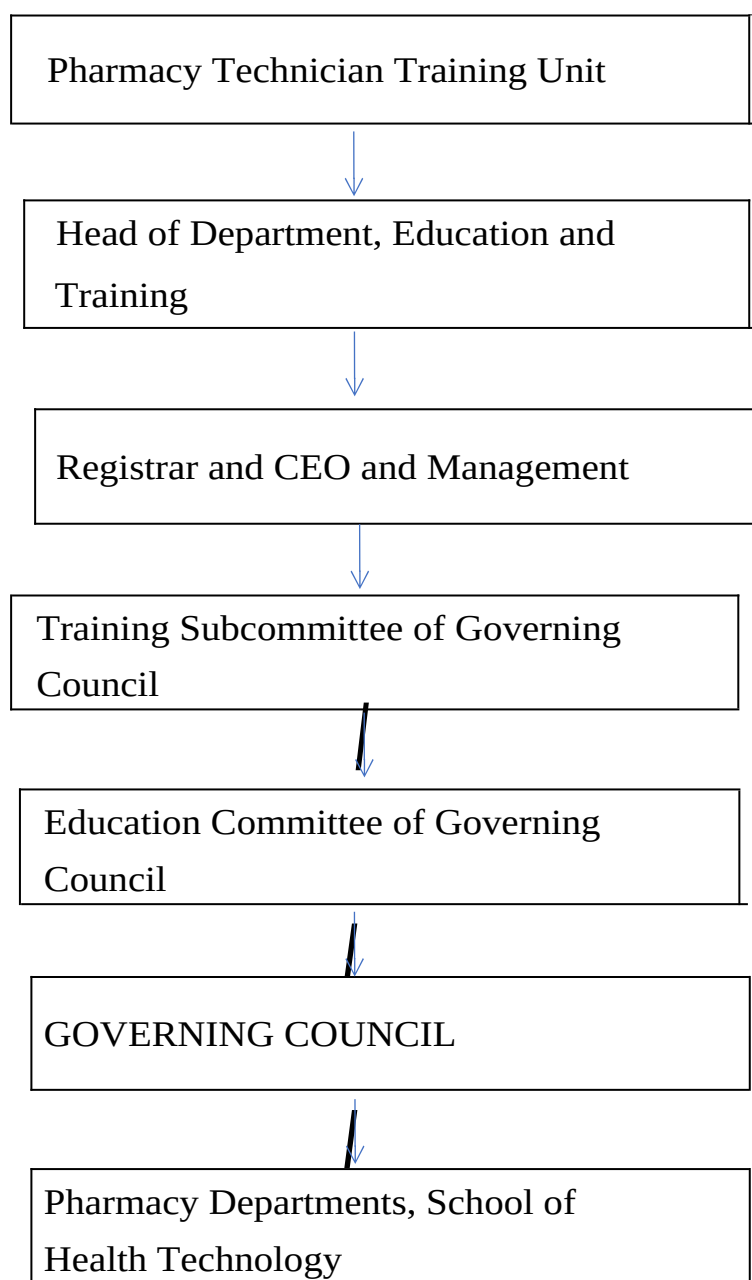
For example, within the PCN, this responsibility lies with the Education and Training Department, where a designated pharmacist serves as desk officer.

Curriculum development—whether creating a new programme or reviewing an existing one—begins in this department and culminates in the office of the Registrar/Chief Executive Officer (CEO), working with the management team to finalize content.

At PCN, the Training Subcommittee, a standing committee of the Governing Council, reviews PT training matters. Its recommendations are passed to the Education Committee, then to the Governing Council for deliberation and approval. Only after this process is the approved curriculum issued to the Schools of Health Technology (SHTs) for implementation.

(See Table 1 below for a flow chart of this process.)

Table 1



1.2 Accreditation Requirements and Evaluation Format

The primary objective of an accreditation exercise is to ensure that pre-set standards—particularly in human resources, infrastructure, and training facilities for Pharmacy Technicians (PTs)—are met. In other words, the reality on the ground must align with the established benchmarks.

To uphold the integrity of the accreditation process, the **Governing Council or Board** should constitute accreditation teams based on recommendations from the Registrar and Chief Executive Officer (CEO). Wherever possible, these teams should include:

- Pharmacists from universities;
- Pharmacists from Departments of Pharmaceutical Services within State or Provincial Ministries of Health;
- Retired pharmacists with prior public service experience;
- Pharmacists in community practice or from the Pharmaceutical Society.

However, given the sensitive nature of evaluation, preference should be given to pharmacists serving as public officers or civil servants, whose accountability mechanisms discourage profit-driven bias and ensure impartiality.

Application Form for the Accreditation of Schools of Health Technology (Form PTI)

1. Particulars of the School

- a. Name of School
- b. Address
- c. Local Government Area State
- d. Telephone, fax, email
- e. Date of establishment of the School
- f. Date of commencement of the Pharmacy Technician Training
- g. Other departments in the School
- h. Supervising Ministry

2. The Governing Council

- a. Number of members
- b. Name of Chairman
- c. Qualifications of Chairman
- d. Number of pharmacists on the Council

3. Staffing

- **Principal/Provost**
 - i. Name
 - ii. Qualifications (with dates)
 - iii. Date of assumption of office
 - iv. Years of experience in SHTs
- **Head of Department (Pharmacy)**
 - i. Name
 - ii. Qualifications (with dates)
 - iii. Professional registration number (with date)
 - iv. Current license number (with date)
 - v. Years of experience in SHTs
 - vi. Date of joining the School
 - vii. Courses taught
- **Other Pharmacists on Staff**

For each:

 - i. Name
 - ii. Qualifications (with dates)
 - iii. Years of experience in SHTs
 - iv. Full-time/Part-time
 - v. Courses taught
 - vi. Registration number / Current license number

(Use additional sheets if required)

- **Other Teaching Staff**
 - i. Name
 - ii. Qualifications (with dates)
 - iii. Years of teaching experience in SHTs

Signature/Date

Official Stamp

1.3 Institutions for the Training of PTs

For PTs to be available in the workforce, there must be **designated training institutions** approved by the Regulatory Agency. In Nigeria, these are primarily **Schools of Health Technology (SHTs)** operated by State Governments.

Challenges have arisen where some polytechnics—and in one notable case, a Teaching Hospital—attempted to initiate PT training. Such moves were strongly resisted by the PCN to safeguard programme integrity.

All designated institutions must strictly adhere to the **accreditation manual and format** prescribed by the Regulatory Agency.

Entry Requirements (Nigeria Example)

Candidates must possess a **Senior Secondary School Certificate Examination (SSSCE)** from WAEC with passes in at least four subjects, including Chemistry, Biology, Mathematics, and English, in not more than three sittings. Equivalent passes in GCE or NECO are accepted. The programme typically runs for **36 months**, after which graduates may work as Pharmacy Technicians under the supervision of registered pharmacists.

1.4 Indexing of Students and Examinations

A student indexing system should be implemented. In Nigeria, SHTs verify students' entry qualifications within six (6) months of admission and submit them for indexing by the PCN, using prescribed forms and paying the required fees.

The Regulatory Agency should also appoint **External Examiners** to supervise final examinations. Guidelines include:

- External Examiners must be pharmacists with at least **10 years post-registration experience** and proven expertise in training.
- Schools must apply at least **four weeks** in advance for appointment of an examiner.
- The External Examiner supervises examinations, validates results, and submits a report directly to the Regulatory Agency.

The **Training Subcommittee, Education Committee**, and ultimately the **Governing Council** review these reports before final approval and release of results.

1.5 Registration, Licensing/Permits, and Fees

Upon qualification, Pharmacy Technicians are entered into the **Register of PTs** maintained by the Registrar of the Regulatory Agency.

- A **Permit** (to distinguish it from pharmacists' licenses) is issued, authorizing PTs to work in approved organizations.
- The Permit is also a requirement for promotion exercises in government establishments.
- The Regulatory Agency prescribes fees for **initial registration** and **periodic renewal** of the Permit.

Maintaining an up-to-date Register is essential for professional regulation and accountability.

1.6 Continuing Education, Workshops, and Train-the-Trainer Programmes

To ensure sustained competence, Regulatory Agencies must enforce **Continuing Professional Development (CPD)** for PTs, similar to pharmacists.

Key approaches include:

- Periodic **training workshops** for PT tutors (who are pharmacists), organized centrally or regionally;
- Incorporating **peer review mechanisms** to ensure adherence to curriculum standards;
- Compulsory CPD for PTs to keep pace with new developments in pharmaceutical technology;
- Structured “Train-the-Trainer” programmes to strengthen teaching capacity within SHTs.

Conclusion

Pharmacy Technicians play a vital role in ensuring effective healthcare delivery as auxiliary staff across the **ECOWAS region**. The challenge for regulators lies in

providing sufficient training and exposure to PTs while avoiding role confusion with pharmacists.

Nonetheless, the harmonization of **curricula and accreditation standards** across ECOWAS is both urgent and necessary, especially in pursuit of healthcare-related **Millennium Development Goals (MDGs)** and broader access to quality healthcare services.

By sharing human resources across member states and strengthening regulatory oversight, the region will be better positioned to combat parasitic and communicable diseases that transcend borders.

Ultimately, a **harmonized PT curriculum** will provide a benchmark recognized across ECOWAS, fostering mobility, quality assurance, and improved healthcare outcomes.

Thank you.